

PRAKASH KARAT

60, CPI(M) GENERAL SECRETARY (4)

RED ALERT

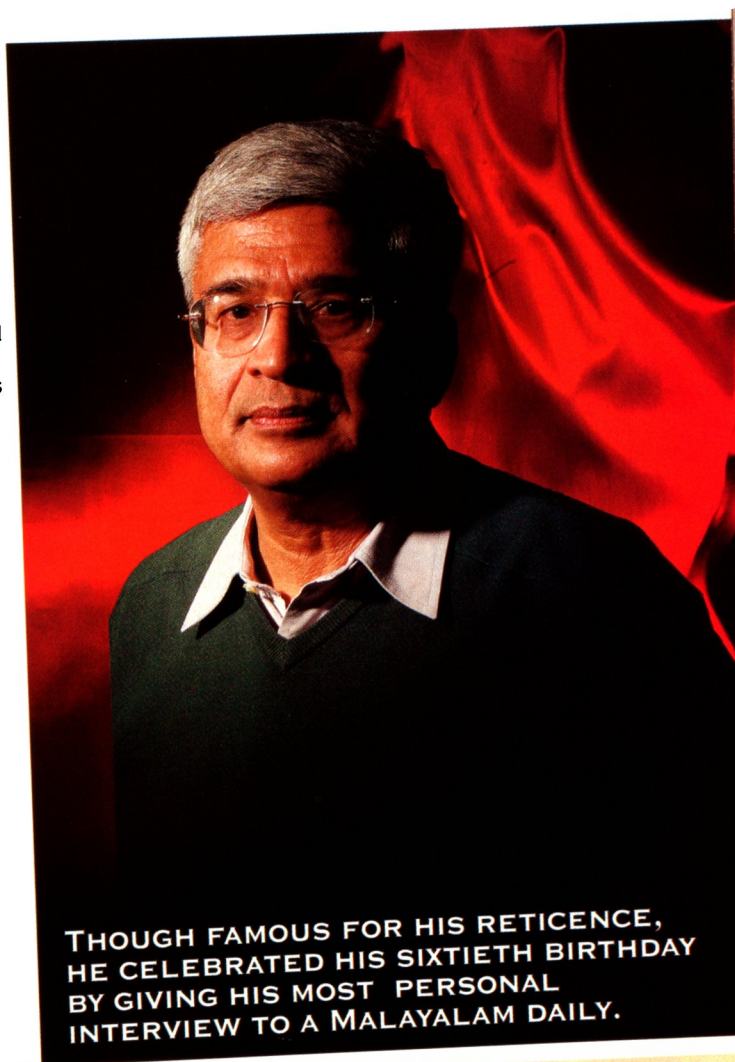
BECAUSE he can derail any policy decision taken by Manmohan Singh's Cabinet. Because when the prime minister gave him an ultimatum on the showpiece of his tenure, the Indo-US nuclear deal, Karat called his bluff. Because his strident objections set the Left's agenda and over-rode the softening stand of some of his colleagues. Because his party rejected most of the options given by the Congress for the post of the President. Because his man became the vice-president.

TIME OFF: Loves Carnatic and western classical music and crime fiction. The Edinburgh-based Ian Rankin is a favourite. Perhaps because he went to university there.

SHOULD BE EMBARRASSED ABOUT: Nandigram. It dented his self-righteousness.

STRANGE BUT TRUE: Got married under a pseudonym when he and Brinda were underground during the Emergency. He was Sudhir and she was Rita.

FOOD QUIRK: Calls himself a non-vegetarian but eats only fish. Goes to the United News of India canteen in Delhi for dosa.



THOUGH FAMOUS FOR HIS RETICENCE, HE CELEBRATED HIS SIXTIETH BIRTHDAY BY GIVING HIS MOST PERSONAL INTERVIEW TO A MALAYALAM DAILY.

that her *maut ka saudagar* speech cost them the Gujarat elections, no one dares admit it. Because her power doesn't trip even if the party flounders.

THE BIG DISCOVERY: That neither she nor son Rahul has a magic wand to save the Congress, especially in Uttar Pradesh.

FAVOURITE GOVERNANCE TOOLS: Ahmad Patel, Pranab Mukherjee and Veerappa Moily, in no particular order.

IS READING: *The Music Room* by Namita

Devidayal and *Memoirs* by anti-apartheid activist Ahmad M. Kathrada.

THE IDEOLOGY: Drawing room socialism. Steers socially correct bills such as rural employment guarantee and RTI.

THE GIRLIE THING: Takes a break from the starched sari and prim hairstyles by switching to a ponytail-and-salwar kameez.

TIME OFF: Is a great giggler, as some women MPs discovered recently when they read out SMS jokes to her.